policymakers had worried that India was too big to fail, by the end of 1967 it seemed able to survive strategic and economic stress tests.

Indian policymakers, on their part, increasingly questioned the extent to which they could rely on Moscow and Washington to help tackle their external and internal China challenge. The 1965 war strengthened their desire to continue to diversify India's dependence, as well as their efforts to try to reduce it—an inclination only reinforced by domestic political developments. In terms of the US relationship, they found the demands of dependence increasingly burdensome. They still, however, needed American assistance and, therefore, to sustain their US option. Simultaneously though, awareness that India was losing traction in Washington would lead policymakers to try to strengthen their domestic options, maintain their Soviet option, and also explore their nuclear, looking eastward, and China options.

This chapter looks at the period between 1965 and 1968. It considers the final few months of the Shastri government and the first few months of Indira Gandhi's premiership, when American officials dealt with the fact that they could not let India fail in the face of an assertive China, and Indian officials realized that they could not jettison the US partnership for that same reason. The next section outlines the disillusionment that set in between the countries, as disappointment grew over the other's approach toward confronting China and strengthening India. The final section considers the consequent move toward disengagement despite the persistent China threat, with Washington questioning India's utility to its Asia strategy, and India seeking to reduce its dependence on the US.

Dependence (Fall 1965–Spring 1966)

For Indian policymakers, the 1965 war made evident that China continued to be a threat, whether alone or in collaboration with Pakistan.[3] They did not expect the threat to abate. Since early in the Johnson administration, Chinese infrastructure construction timelines in certain strategic areas had made Indian officials worry that 1966–1967 would be a critical period when it came to the China threat.[4] Better military performance in the 1965 war than in the 1962 one had created a sense of confidence but also reinforced India's continued need for external assistance.[5]